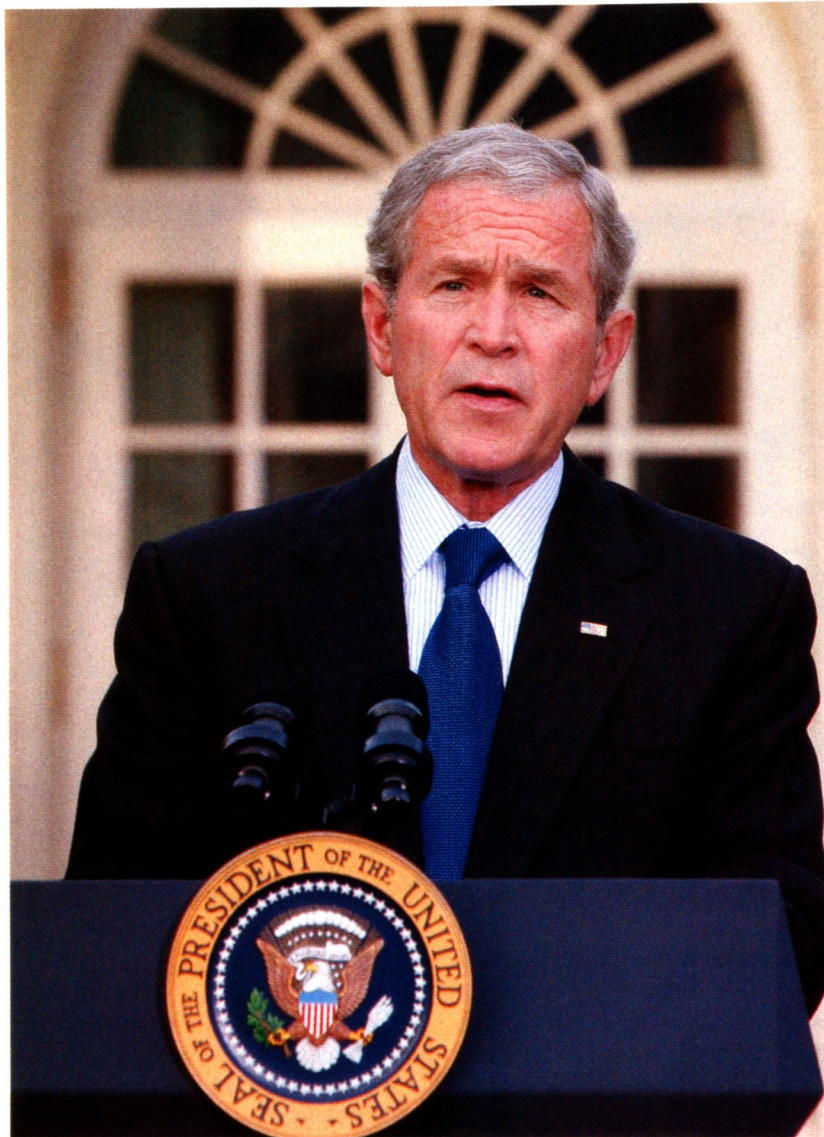


REUTERS, JASON REED



END OF THE ROAD: Outgoing President Bush at the White House

Bush the most unpopular president at home in recent memory, maybe quite unfairly, the Mesopotamian mess further added to the McCain tragedy of being caricatured as George W. by another name. McCain may tell Obama, Senator, if you want to contest against Bush, you should have done it four years ago. But the former bomber pilot refuses to abandon the "winning" war in Iraq to win an election. For Obama, Iraq is the wrong war, and he promises to bring the US troops home within 16 months of his presidency. His priority is Afghanistan. He may sound soft on Iran when he says he's willing to talk with the regime; but he is tough on Pakistan. He won't allow Pakistan to become a sanctuary of Al Qaeda, and American aid to Pakistan will be conditional to Islamabad's progress in closing down terror camps and stopping Taliban from using Pakistan as a base. And here comes the Obama Ultimatum: America will act militarily if it is convinced that Osama bin Laden is having a good time in the mountains with the knowledge of Pakistan. That should bring some cheer to New Delhi.

His vice-presidential nominee, Joe Biden, a proven foreign policy wonk, may have been a bit undiplomatic when he said that Obama will be tested severely within the first six months of his presidency. He was talking truth, though it was more appreciated by McCain, who was quick to make the maximum out of Biden's straight talk. "I have already been tested," he declared in his next



McCain is now being looked at as a SYNONYM for imaginary Bush Part Three.

meltdown, as life-changing as 9/11 for America, both candidates have to be compassionate and imaginative. Obama wants to tax the rich and spread the wealth, inviting accusation of Marxist control from the right. "Obama wants to distribute the wealth, and I want to create it... He is the redistributor-in-chief and I'm the commander-in-chief..." so goes the McCain mantra on the stump. Obama challenges the claim: "John McCain wants to double down on George Bush's disastrous policies—not only by making permanent the Bush tax cuts for the wealthy."

Unfortunately for McCain, he has become a synonym for the imaginary Bush Part Three. If 9/11 inaugurated the Bush presidency to a heroic start, the fall of the mighty towers of capitalism slowed down the pace of the McCain campaign in the final decisive stage. If Iraq made

stump speech. And one test he is finding it difficult to endure is his choice of Palin, the governor of Alaska, as his running mate. Was McCain's selection of the warrior queen from the frontier a classical case of fatal attraction in politics? Was it a Freudian slip from an old man or a smart move to close the generational as well as the gender divide in an arena minus Hillary Clinton? The Palin mystique has worn off. She is a mascot of Conservative values only for the hardest core of GOP. Palinologists, though, are arguing that the lady is here to stay, with or without a party-funded, \$150,000 wardrobe—and irrespective of whatever happens on November 4—as the next leader of the party. Unknowingly, McCain may have chosen the post-Bush face of GOP. At the moment, the 44-year-old fellow maverick has become a liability for the old veteran.